

Navam Niles

Climate governance researcher and lecturer

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Profile

Climate governance researcher and lecturer with more than a decade of applied research and university teaching experience across Sri Lanka and Australia. Work spans climate adaptation, development finance, and environmental policy, including co-authored publications in Science, WIREs Climate Change, and Sustainable Development and development of the Australian Adaptation Database. Lecturer (Practice) at Monash University, PhD researcher at the University of Melbourne, and Fellow of Advance HE.

Areas of expertise

Climate adaptation governance • Environmental policy • Development finance and safeguards • Political economy • Policy coherence • Qualitative and quantitative research • Stakeholder engagement • University teaching and assessment • Research data management

Current teaching appointments

Lecturer (Practice)

Monash University | July 2026–present | Part-time, fixed-term

- Coordinate ATS2548, Climate and Environmental Policy and Management, within the School of Social Sciences, Faculty of Arts.
- Design and deliver workshops on climate and environmental policy, using applied cases, stakeholder analysis, and policy instruments.
- Coordinate assessment guidance and group assessment arrangements, maintain Moodle resources, and support students through collaborative learning activities.

Teaching Associate and Tutor

University of Melbourne | May 2023–present | Sessional appointments

- Co-design and deliver seminars for Climate Change Politics and Policy (ENST90004), assess written work, and provide feedback through Canvas; contribute to semester teaching and the intensive format introduced in 2025.
- Tutor Adapting to Climate Change (ENST90034) in 2026, supporting discussion of vulnerability, adaptation pathways, maladaptation, community approaches, and adaptation governance.
- Tutor Environmental Politics and Management (GEOG20003) and Sustainable Development (GEOG30019) in 2026, using discussion and active learning to examine power, competing interests, the SDGs, and development practice.
- Taught Global Environmental Politics (POLS30022) in 2024, using small-group activities and reflective weekly summaries; assessed written assignments and Master of Environment research projects across ENST90005, ENST90036, and ENST90025.

Education

PhD in progress | University of Melbourne | May 2023–present

School of Geography, Earth and Atmospheric Sciences. Research examines climate adaptation governance involving external partners, development finance, and infrastructure safeguards.

Master of Laws with Merit, Public International Law | University of London | Awarded December 2020

Examinations conducted by Queen Mary University of London and University College London.

BSc International Relations, Second Class Honours Upper Division | University of London | Awarded August 2012

Examinations conducted by the London School of Economics and Political Science.

Research and policy experience

Research appointments and project work

University of Melbourne | 2023–present

Appointments include Senior Research Associate, December 2024–June 2025, and Research Assistant roles in 2023–2024.

State-Owned Enterprise Transition Monitor | Project work from December 2024, continuing in 2026

- Develop research frameworks for assessing how state ownership, political economy, and firm capabilities shape the climate transition of state-owned enterprises.
- Contribute to indicator selection, metadata, research database design, stakeholder interviews, and the project's theory of change.
- Prepare working methods and technical briefs that distinguish observed actions and outcomes from conditional expectations, and make evidence gaps and uncertainty explicit.
- Contribute to source governance and coding arrangements for a research prototype, including provenance, comparability, and readiness for analysis.

Australian Adaptation Database and adaptation research | Research Assistant appointment, May 2023–December 2024

- Designed and tested research database structures using Excel, SQLite, and PostgreSQL; wrote SQL queries and supported research workflows for the NESP Climate Systems Hub adaptation project.
- Contributed to literature review, methodology, and development of an accessible public database of adaptation activities.
- Co-authored the Australian Adaptation Database dataset and the 2026 WIREs Climate Change paper, Best Practice in Climate Change Adaptation.

City Portrait for Greater Melbourne | Research Assistant appointment, October–December 2023

- Collected and organised environmental indicator data for work with Open Corridor and Regen Melbourne, and liaised with utilities and local government data providers.
- Prepared a report examining Infrastructure Victoria's Future Scenarios against the City Portrait methodology.

Consultant and Facilitator

International Organization for Migration | Sri Lanka | March–May 2023

- Synthesised migration research into a roadmap for sustainable migration in Sri Lanka.
- Facilitated workshops involving public agencies, development organisations, and private-sector stakeholders to discuss research findings and priorities.

Research Consultant and Research Associate

Centre for Poverty Analysis | Sri Lanka | 2015–2023

External consultant from 2015; Research Associate within the IGAF programme from February 2019.

- Designed research proposals and methodologies, conducted literature reviews, analysed qualitative and quantitative evidence, and facilitated knowledge-sharing workshops.
- Examined climate adaptation, clean energy security, environmental policy coherence, climate-related conflict, and sustainable development.
- Contributed to research on Sri Lankan agriculture and policy coherence with the Stockholm Environment Institute, and to studies of labour and sustainability in apparel value chains.
- Authored a Southern Voice review informing debate on the UN's Our Common Agenda. Subsequent publications include collaborative work released in 2024 and 2026.

Earlier teaching and professional experience

Visiting Lecturer and Lecturer in Charge

Bandaranaike Centre for International Studies | Sri Lanka and remote | 2017–2025

- Taught international relations, global environmental politics, non-traditional security, and the post-Cold War world order across diploma programmes.
- Developed lesson plans and contributed to programme delivery, including remote teaching in 2024 and a co-lecturer role in International Organizations and Global Governance in 2025.

Visiting Lecturer

Royal Institute of Colombo | University of London EMFSS programmes | 2013–2023

- Taught eight undergraduate modules in international relations, development, foreign policy, environmental politics, and political thought under programmes with academic direction from LSE.
- Prepared lessons and tutorials for cohorts with different disciplinary interests and levels of prior knowledge.

Visiting Lecturer

ICBT Colombo | Liverpool John Moores University postgraduate programme | 2022–2023

- Taught International Politics and Development Asia Pacific and Conflict and Warfare in International Law.
- Designed and assessed postgraduate assignments using university assessment criteria.

Moderator and Resource Person for Digital Module Production

Helvetas Intercooperation | Sri Lanka | 2020–2021

- Researched and produced scripts for digital learning content on youth education and employment.

Climate Change Project Management

Janathakshan | Sri Lanka | 2014–2018

- Managed Southern Voices work on climate adaptation and pro-poor low-carbon development, liaising with national and international partners.
- Developed an online adaptation database and preparation tool to organise information on Sri Lankan adaptation projects.
- Served as Manager, Southern Voices for Adaptation, April 2016–March 2017.

Assistant Research Analyst and IT Group Lead

Verité Research | Sri Lanka | 2012–2014

- Compiled data and analysis for the weekly Media Analysis publication.
- Developed a database for researchers' timesheets across research streams.

Additional qualifications

University of London | Awarded December 2019

- Postgraduate Diploma in Laws with Merit, specialising in Law and Development.
- Postgraduate Certificate in Laws with Merit, specialising in Environmental and Natural Resources Law.

Selected publications and research outputs

Journal articles and dataset

- Barnett, J., Brullo, T., Boulter, S., and **Niles, N.** (2026). Best Practice in Climate Change Adaptation. *WIREs Climate Change*, 17(2), e70051. <https://doi.org/10.1002/wcc.70051>
- Browne, K., Dzebo, A., Shawoo, Z., Cardenas, M., Chalaye, P., Faus Onbargi, A., Muhoza, C., Nicdao, P., Makhanya, N., **Niles, N.**, and Singh, P. (2026). National Policy Coherence Counts for Reducing Inequality in Global Climate and Development Agendas. *Sustainable Development*. <https://doi.org/10.1002/sd.71117>
- Morrison, T. H., et al., including **Niles, N.** (2025). Governing Novel Climate Interventions in Rapidly Changing Oceans. *Science*, 389(6759), eadq0174. <https://doi.org/10.1126/science.adq0174>
- Brullo, T., Waters, E., Barnett, J., Boulter, S., **Niles, N.**, Bagot Jewitt, S., Miranda, A., Gmeiner, K.-L., Sabdia, F., and Jha, K. (2025). The Australian Adaptation Database (Version 1) [Dataset]. University of Melbourne. <https://doi.org/10.26188/29208161>
- Chan, S., et al., including **Niles, N.** (2019). Promises and risks of nonstate action in climate and sustainability governance. *WIREs Climate Change*, e572. <https://doi.org/10.1002/wcc.572>

Book chapters and policy publications

- de Alwis, T., Amarasinghe, S., Azmy, N., Perera, M., Fernando, K., and **Niles, N.** (2024). Policy Coherence in Sri Lanka's Agriculture Sector: Aligning Climate Action and Reducing Inequalities. Centre for Poverty Analysis.
- S nit, C.-A., et al., including **Niles, N.** (2022). Inclusiveness. In *The Political Impact of the Sustainable Development Goals: Transforming Governance Through Global Goals?* Cambridge University Press, pp. 116–139. <https://doi.org/10.1017/9781009082945.006>
- **Niles, N.** (2022). Our Common Agenda: Building legitimacy for resilient futures in the Global South. *Southern Voice*, Occasional Paper 78.
- Fernando, K., Arambepola, C., **Niles, N.**, and Ranawana, A. (2020). The opportunities and risks for achieving sustainable labour in a global value chain: A case study from Sri Lanka's apparel sector. *Southern Voice*, Occasional Paper 65.
- **Niles, N.**, and Fernando, K. (2017). Implementing the SDGs: Responding to the Challenges of Interconnectivity and Balance. *Southern Voice*, Occasional Paper 39.
- **Niles, N.** (2016). Institutional Context of Community-based Adaptation. In *Enhancing Adaptation to Climate Change in Developing Countries Through Community-based Adaptation: Think Globally and Act Locally*. African Centre for Technology Studies Press, pp. 29–44.

Book review

- **Niles, N.** (2025). Review of John Duerk (Ed.), *Environmental philosophy, politics, and policy*. *Journal of Political Ecology*, 32(1). <https://doi.org/10.2458/jpe.8337>

Leadership and academic service

- Graduate Researcher Representative, SGEAS Graduate Research Committee, University of Melbourne, 2026. Selected in December 2025.
- Co-coordinator, Asia and Pacific Working Group, Earth System Governance Project, March 2026–present.
- Member, Governing Changing Oceans Program.
- Member, Melbourne Climate Futures Academy, University of Melbourne.
- Peer Mentor, APRU Certificate in Global Climate Change Leadership, April–May 2025. Supported student preparation for simulated climate negotiations and pledges.
- Volunteer professional staff support, Course Academic Progress Committee, University of Melbourne, 2023 and 2025.

Professional recognition and development

- Fellow of Advance HE (FHEA), awarded 15 May 2026.
- Melbourne Teaching Certificate, University of Melbourne, December 2024.
- Certificate in Small-Group Teaching, University of Melbourne, December 2023.
- CMS Interdisciplinary Spring School, Centre for Marine Socioecology, 2023. Completed the programme on inter- and transdisciplinary approaches for sustainable marine futures.
- University of Melbourne Grand Challenges programme, June 2024. Co-authored a team digital strategy report for Artists for Kids Culture.
- Project Management certificate, University of Melbourne, June 2024.
- APRU Student Climate Change Simulation, participant, September 2024.
- Young Global Changers programme, 2020–2021. Completed the extended programme and participated in two digital Global Solutions Summits.

Scholarships and research funding

- Melbourne Research Scholarship, University of Melbourne, commenced May 2023.
- Science Abroad Travelling Scholarship, SGEAS, University of Melbourne, 2024: A\$2,000 for research travel.
- SGEAS studentship, University of Melbourne, 2024: A\$3,000 in research support.

Earlier recognition

- Young Global Changers scholarship, Think20 Summit GLOBAL SOLUTIONS, Berlin, 28–31 May 2017. Selected as one of 100 participants from more than 1,300 applicants.
- Joint highest mark in Introduction to Modern Political Thought, University of London International Programmes; recognition letter dated 1 October 2010.

Research tools and languages

Research and data: SQL, SQLite, PostgreSQL, Python, R, NVivo, and LaTeX.

Teaching and collaboration: Canvas, Moodle, Google Classroom, Microsoft 365, and Google Workspace.

Languages: English, Sinhala, and Tamil.

Referees available on request.